

SOP – Front Office – Credit Card Acceptance in Hotels

SOP Number: Front Office SOP – 37

Department: Front Desk

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Time to Train: 30 Minutes

Overview

This SOP defines the standard operating procedure for accepting credit cards at the hotel front desk. Staff must understand the hotel's Credit Card Acceptance Policy and follow all steps to protect both the guest and the hotel from unnecessary risk or fraud.

Procedure

1. Request Guest to Present Credit Card

- If the guest indicates they will settle the account by credit card upon check-in, request them to physically present the card.
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2. Check Signature Specimen on Credit Card

- Verify that the signature on the credit card matches the signature on the guest's passport and registration card.
 - If the signatures do not match, the credit card **cannot be accepted**.
 - Confirm the guest is the genuine cardholder.
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3. Check Credit Card Validity

- Check the expiration date printed on the card.
 - Expired cards will not be accepted by the bank and must be declined.
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4. Get Pre-Approval Amount via EDC Machine

- Use the EDC (Electronic Data Capture) or Credit Card Terminal machine to obtain a pre-approval amount.
 - The pre-approval should be **1.5 times the total room charge** for the entire expected stay duration.
 - Print the credit card voucher from the EDC or Terminal machine.
 - If the Property Management System (PMS) / Hotel Software has a built-in payment module, use it accordingly.
 - This ensures sufficient approval amount to protect hotel revenue.
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5. Credit Card Tokenization in Hotel Software

Credit card tokens are encrypted representations of card data that enable secure payment processing via a connected payment gateway.

How tokens work:

- Tokens can be created from within hotel software or via a connected EFTPOS terminal (when using hotel software Pay or a compatible payment gateway).
- Multiple tokens can be associated with a guest profile, company, or travel agent.
- Tokens created via the receipt screen are recorded in the audit trail.
- Payments via Pay By Link or credit card receipt automatically generate a token from the entered card data.
- Tokens remain on the profile until manually removed by a user.
- Token descriptions are optional but useful when more than one token exists on a profile.
- Merging guest profiles, companies, or travel agents will carry over associated tokens.
- Tokens from a previous payment gateway will not be visible after switching gateways.

Benefits of Credit Card Tokenization:

Benefit	Description
Improved Security	Encrypted tokens are far harder for hackers to exploit than raw card data
Increased Efficiency	No need to re-enter card details for each transaction
Enhanced Guest Experience	Provides a more convenient and secure payment flow

6. Imprint Credit Card on Relevant Forms (*Outdated — No Longer in Use*)

Note: This step describes a legacy process that is no longer practiced in modern hotels.

- Previously, the credit card was imprinted on the cardholder's registration card and liability form.
 - A credit card voucher was attached to the back of the registration card for bank reference.
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7. Attach Voucher

- Attach the credit card voucher to the back of the cardholder's registration card.
 - File all credit card vouchers properly to prevent loss and facilitate easy retrieval.
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8. Pay Attention to Special Arrangements

Be alert to the following special cases when checking guest credit for outlet cashiers:

- **VIP Guests:** Guests classified as top VIP by hotel management — handle with extra care as any lapse may affect hotel reputation or revenue.
- **In-House Account Guests:** Guest's consumption across all hotel outlets is charged to an internal house account.
- **Manager / Credit Manager Approved:** Guest is authorized by the hotel manager or credit manager to settle the bill upon departure.
- **Company Guaranteed Stays:** Guest's consumption is covered by a company that has a sufficient deposit or a signed credit privilege agreement with the hotel.

Special arrangements must be taken seriously in daily operations, as errors can have a significant impact on both hotel revenue and reputation.

9. Accepted Credit Cards

The following credit cards are typically accepted at hotels and resorts:

- American Express
 - Diners Club International
 - Visa International
 - MasterCard International
 - ICB Card
 - JCB Card
 - UnionPay
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10. General Points to Note

- Always prioritize hotel benefit when assessing a card.

- Decline unacceptable cards promptly to avoid complications for both the guest and the hotel.
 - Act in the best interest of both the hotel and the guest at all times.
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Training Summary Questions

Use the following questions to assess staff understanding after training:

1. Why is it important to check the signature on the credit card?
 2. What special arrangements require extra attention during credit card checks?
 3. Give a few examples of major credit cards accepted at hotels.
 4. What are the key points to note when handling credit card transactions?
 5. How does credit card tokenization work within hotel software, and what are its advantages?
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Source: SetupMyHotel.com — Front Office SOP #37